

SHAILESH RAWAL



Case Not Closed

AHMEDABAD The daylight murder of Haren Pandya, Narendra Modi's main rival in the Gujarat BJP, was the first major blow to the chief minister after the December 2002 assembly elections. Pandya, the former Gujarat minister of state for home, was shot dead in broad daylight in Ahmedabad on March 26, 2003, barely three months after Modi forced the BJP high-command to deny a ticket to him in the December 2002 Gujarat assembly polls.

The CBI, which investigated the case, found that the murder was engineered by some radical Muslim clerics led by one Mufti Sufian Patangia, now believed to be in Pakistan, and ISI-trained Muslim youths from Gujarat and Andhra Pradesh. They were seeking revenge for the killings of Muslims during the 2002 Gujarat riots. Pandya had been charged with leading violent Hindu mobs on Muslims. As many as 16 persons were charged in the case under

LAST LEG: Pandya's body being taken for cremation

POTA, out of which four are still absconding. Pandya's father Vithalbhair has continuously alleged that his son's murder was engineered by Modi himself.

Last week, the special POTA court sentenced nine of the 12 accused to life imprisonment while awarding lesser sentences to three others. Amongst those who got life terms is Hyderabad-based Asghar Ali, who pumped five bullets into Pandya.

After the verdict, Vithalbhair sought re-investigation into the case by the CBI, which, he said, was influenced by L.K. Advani, the then Union home minister, in the NDA regime. He is now planning legal action. Pandya's wife Jagruti says, "I'll meet the chief minister and request him for a reinvestigation. There are too many holes in the way the case has been probed." Meanwhile, Modi continues to maintain a stoic silence over the issue. **by Uday Mahurkar**

Rumble Over a Ring

BHOPAL After a Madhya Pradesh minister created a huge rumble over Hindustan Latex's product Crezendo, the battery-powered rubber vibrating ring sold with condoms, chemists are laughing all their way to the bank with shooting sales owing to the curiosity factor.

Waxing indignant at what he described as a "sex toy", state PWD and

PANKAJ TIWARI



TOY STORY: The condom

Energy Minister Kailash Vijayvargiya has demanded a ban on its sale and shot off a protest letter to the prime minister. But the state Government is yet to decide on the demand for a ban

In a state where hardcore saffron elements are quick to jump the gun on almost any issue, the lack of enthusiasm over the minister's demand for the ban is now being seen as a reflection of rift in the state Government. Vijayvargiya is viewed as an ambitious leader and a potential rival of Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chauhan.

The minister's demand for yoga instruction, instead of such "gimmicks" to enhance sexual prowess, is in line with Shivraj's own faith in yoga. But a section of the state BJP feels that repeated controversies could project the government in a bad light.

by Ambresh Mishra

OBJECT OF DESIRE

Slim Fit

HEWLETT-PACKARD PAVILION M8090IN PC
Rs 77,990

The Pavilion desktop PC features a new design aimed at conserving space. The wireless keyboard is slim with easy to use low profile keys. The PC's Intel Core 2 Duo

processor combines a huge 250 GB hard disk and 512 MB DDR2 dedicated graphics memory for videos. It also has a TV tuner with personal video recorder and FM radio. The monitor can be swivelled 160 degrees horizontally or vertically. The widescreen LCD monitor offers more viewable area and sharper display. Comes with a remote control for the ultimate digital entertainment experience at your fingertips.

